

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN IRAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Iran turns above all on water, and on a hard truth the state itself has come to acknowledge: the country is draining its rivers, lakes, and aquifers faster than nature can replace them, and the cause is less the drought and the warming climate, real as those are, than decades of its own mismanagement — the unchecked building of dams, the over-pumping of groundwater through a million wells, the diversion of water between basins, and the relentless expansion of thirsty agriculture. A great lake once the largest in the Middle East has been reduced to a bed of salt; a storied river runs dry through a historic city; hundreds of plains are sinking as the aquifers beneath them collapse; and the exposed lakebeds send salt and dust across the country, choking its cities' air. Alongside the water, the ancient Hyrcanian forests of the Caspian coast, a treasure recognised by the world, are scorched by drought and fire. There is no landmark community victory to point to, the political space is closed and repressive, and environmental work in Iran has carried genuine danger. But the crisis is one the state itself has recognised, and that opens a narrow, real space.

Those who would defend Iran's waters and forests cannot do so openly, but that narrow space exists because the state itself acknowledges the emergency — and the tools are technical, scientific, and within-system. The distinctive lever is the **state's own acknowledgment of the existential water crisis**: an emergency the government has itself recognised can be pressed, carefully, toward reform and sustainable use, on the state's own terms. The **dam-building and groundwater over-extraction** that drive the crisis can be **scrutinised technically and scientifically**, an evidence-based case the state's own admission invites. The ancient **Hyrcanian forests**, a recognised world treasure, can be defended through the **international heritage frameworks**. The **deadly air and dust crisis** — the salt and dust from the exposed lakebeds — is visible, measurable, and tied to the drying waters, a hard evidence no one can deny. And **Iran's strong national science and the international scientific frameworks** carry the technical case. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The crisis is largely self-inflicted, so reform means confronting entrenched agricultural, water, and development interests and decades of policy. The state acknowledges the emergency, but the political space is closed and repressive, and — this matters above all — environmental work in Iran has carried genuine danger, and those who undertook it have faced serious consequences. The drought and the sanctions compound the crisis. And there is no landmark victory to point to. So the work must be careful, strictly environmental, technical, and within-system — never framed as political, protecting everyone involved absolutely, because dissent framed as political is met harshly. And the honest prize is the crisis pressed toward reform, a dam or over-extraction scrutinised, the forests defended, the dust documented — on the state's own acknowledged terms, not an open stop. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot mount open opposition in a closed and repressive state, and you must never try, because environmental work here has carried genuine danger. What can be done is to work through the one opening the state itself has created: its own acknowledgment of an existential water crisis. Press that crisis, carefully and technically, toward reform; scrutinise the dams and over-extraction scientifically; defend the Hyrcanian forests through the world's frameworks; document the deadly dust — all strictly on the environment, never

political, and protecting everyone involved absolutely.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Iran is among the most dangerous settings in this guide for environmental work, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. This is not a fight you win by opposition — the space is closed and the danger real. It is a careful, technical, within-system effort worked through the state's own acknowledgment of the crisis, whose realistic prize is the crisis pressed toward reform, a dam or over-extraction scrutinised, the forests defended — not an open stop. Keep everything strictly environmental, never political, and protect everyone involved absolutely, because the consequences of crossing that line have been severe.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Power rests with a closed and repressive state, but the crisis it has acknowledged creates channels a careful, technical effort can reach: the **water, agriculture, and environment authorities** that run the dams, wells, and basins and administer the state's own crisis programmes; the **scientific and technical institutions** whose expertise the state relies on; and the **international heritage and scientific frameworks** that guard the forests and carry the science. These, engaged strictly on the environment, are who can be reached. Map them, and the danger, before spending a week on it.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A dam, a diversion, or an expansion of thirsty agriculture advances by state decision, but the state's own acknowledgment of the water crisis is the opening: a technical, scientific case can show how a project deepens the emergency the government itself has recognised, and press for its scrutiny or reform. For the forests, the entry point is the international heritage frameworks. For the dust, the visible, measurable evidence. Enter always technically, within the system, and strictly on the environment.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water: which dams, wells, and diversions drain the rivers and aquifers, and how they deepen the crisis the state acknowledges. Follow the agriculture: which thirsty expansion drives the over-use. Follow the forests: which logging or fire threatens the Hyrcanian treasure. Follow the dust: where the exposed lakebeds choke the air. The leverage lies in the state's own acknowledgment, the technical scrutiny, and the international frameworks.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Oversight in a closed state is limited, but the water, agriculture, and environment authorities administering the state's own crisis programmes, the scientific and technical institutions, and the international heritage and scientific frameworks are the channels a careful case engages — holding each, on the state's own acknowledged terms, to the science and the crisis it has recognised.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Iranian effort openly defeats a state-favoured project, and honesty requires saying so — the space is closed and the danger real. What the technical, within-system tools can deliver is the crisis pressed toward reform, a project scrutinised, the forests defended, the dust documented. The single most decisive move is

grounding everything in the state's own acknowledgment of the water crisis and the hard technical evidence, because that acknowledgment is the one opening a closed state has itself created, and because rigorous science on an existential, self-inflicted emergency is harder to dismiss than any protest. The state's own admission is the distinctive lever; the technical scrutiny the sharpest tool; the international frameworks the forests' shield. Nothing here is open or safe by default — but a state that has admitted its crisis can be pressed, carefully, on its own terms.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the dam or diversion draining the water, the over-pumping, the thirsty agriculture, the threat to the forests, the dust. **How does it deepen the acknowledged crisis?** — the tie to the emergency the state itself recognises. **What does the science show?** — the technical, measurable evidence. **Which framework reaches the forests?** — the international heritage regime. **How is everyone kept safe?** — the overriding question, answered by keeping the work strictly environmental, technical, and within-system, and exposing no one. Pick the harm where the state's acknowledgment and the hard evidence give the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, technically and safely. **Layer one: the harm and the crisis** — the dam, diversion, or over-extraction, and how it deepens the water emergency the state acknowledges, documented with hard data. **Layer two: the evidence and the framework** — the technical and scientific case, the international heritage frameworks for the forests, the measurable dust and subsidence. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which authority, institution, or framework to reach, and the absolute discipline of keeping the work strictly environmental, never political, and protecting everyone. A case built on the state's own acknowledgment and rigorous, undeniable science is the one a closed state can be pressed with, safely.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **crisis record**: the state's own acknowledgments and programmes, the drying lakes and rivers, the collapsing aquifers, the subsidence. Gather the **harm record**: the dams, wells, diversions, and thirsty agriculture, and the technical data. Gather the **forest record**: the Hyrcanian treasure, its international heritage status, the drought and fire damage. Gather the **dust record**: the measurable salt and dust from the exposed lakebeds and its air-quality toll. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm the work is strictly environmental, technical, within-system, and exposes no one.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE TECHNICAL AND SCIENTIFIC COALITION

The coalition here is technical and scientific, because it must be — not an opposition. Build it, carefully, from the **scientists and technical experts** whose water, ecology, and air-quality data the state itself uses; the **institutions** administering the crisis programmes; and the **international heritage and scientific frameworks and partners** who guard the forests and carry the science. Frame everything strictly around the water, the forests, the air, and the crisis the state acknowledges, never around anything political; involve no one who could be endangered; and protect everyone absolutely, mindful that dissent framed as political is met harshly.

STEP 4: THE STATE'S ACKNOWLEDGMENT, THE SCIENCE & THE FRAMEWORKS — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are technical, within-system, and constrained, in a dangerous space, so the prize is reform and scrutiny, not a stop.

The State's Own Acknowledgment

The distinctive lever is the **state's own acknowledgment of the existential water crisis**. An emergency the government has itself recognised, and built programmes to address, can be pressed — carefully and technically — toward reform, sustainable use, and the scrutiny of the projects that deepen it, on the state's own terms.

The Technical Scrutiny of the Dams and Groundwater

The **dam-building and groundwater over-extraction** that drive the crisis can be **scrutinised technically and scientifically** — an evidence-based case the state's own admission invites, and one harder to dismiss than protest because it rests on the government's own recognised emergency.

The Forests, the Dust, and the Frameworks

The **Hyrcean forests** can be defended through the **international heritage frameworks**, and the **deadly air and dust** is visible, measurable evidence tied to the drying waters. Pursued together — the state's acknowledgment, the technical scrutiny, and the forests and frameworks — these levers press the crisis toward reform, while everyone involved is protected absolutely.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always to the state's own terms. **For the water and environment authorities**: here is a project that deepens the very crisis you have acknowledged, with the technical evidence. **For the scientific institutions**: here is the rigorous case to carry, within the system. **For the international heritage frameworks**: here is a world treasure, the Hyrcanian forests, under threat. **For the air-quality record**: here is the deadly dust the drying waters produce. **The golden rule**: ground everything in the state's own acknowledgment and undeniable science, keep it strictly environmental and never political, and protect everyone involved absolutely — that is the only safe and effective register here.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care in a closed and repressive state, and never as political dissent. Frame any attention strictly around the **water crisis the state itself acknowledges**, the Hyrcanian forests, and the deadly dust — technical, scientific, and on the state's own recognised terms. Carry it, carefully, through the scientific and international heritage channels, never through anything that reads as opposition. A few cautions govern everything: keep it strictly environmental and technical; never frame it as political; protect everyone; and let the state's own acknowledgment and the hard science carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message technical, strictly environmental, on the state's own terms, and absolutely protective of everyone.

8A — To a water or environment authority: set out how the project deepens the water crisis the state has acknowledged, with the technical evidence.

8B — To a scientific or technical institution: request the data and assessment on the dam, over-extraction, or dust.

8C — On the groundwater: document the over-pumping and subsidence and press for the reform the crisis demands.

8D — To an international heritage framework: flag the threat to the Hyrcanian forests and invoke the world treasure.

8E — On the air and dust: present the measurable evidence tying the deadly dust to the drying waters.

8F — To an international scientific framework: share the technical case and request engagement.

8G — On sustainable-use reform: press, on the state's own terms, for the reform its acknowledged crisis requires.

8H — To the international scientific public: summarise the crisis and the forests — strictly technically — and ask for attention, without exposing anyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: assemble the state's own acknowledgment of the crisis and the technical data on the harm; write the one-page case, strictly technical and on the state's terms; identify the safest channel — usually a scientific institution or a heritage framework. **The fastest-moving levers:** the state's acknowledgment, the technical scrutiny, and the international frameworks. **Emergency action:** for the forests, the international heritage frameworks; for a dam or over-extraction, the state's own crisis programmes. Throughout, keep it strictly environmental and technical, and expose no one.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but closed and dangerous, and the crisis is bound up with entrenched agricultural, water, and development interests and decades of policy. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not an open stop, but the crisis pressed toward reform through the state's own acknowledgment. Lean on the levers the closure cannot easily dismiss: the state's own admission, the undeniable technical science, the international heritage frameworks. And accept the honest limits — the reform is hard, the space closed, the danger real — while still pressing the crisis on the state's own terms and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

In a closed state, questions of power and benefit behind a dam or diversion cannot be pursued openly and must be handled with the greatest care. Where a project serves entrenched or insider interests, respond only through the **technical and within-system channels:** the state's own acknowledgment, the scientific case, the international frameworks. Never through open confrontation or anything political. **On safety and protection:** this note matters greatly. Iran is a closed and repressive state where environmental work has carried genuine danger, and those who undertook it have faced serious consequences. Favour the technical, scientific, and within-system channels over any open confrontation; protect everyone involved

absolutely; be mindful that dissent framed as political is met harshly; frame the work only around the water, the forests, the air, and the crisis the state itself acknowledges, never around anything political. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, technically and within the system. The state's own acknowledgment and the hard data feed the reform case, the technical scrutiny, and the forest and dust arguments at once; the scientific and international coalition organises carefully alongside; any attention stays strictly technical throughout. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the state's acknowledgment and the technical evidence; **months two to six**, engage the water and environment authorities, the scientific institutions, and the international heritage frameworks, on the state's own terms; **beyond**, sustain the careful pressure toward reform and the forests' defence. The core discipline: state's-own-acknowledgment, technically grounded, strictly environmental, and absolute in protecting everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Iran is among the most dangerous grounds in this guide for environmental work, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a state-favoured project can be openly stopped, or that the space is safe, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and environmental work here has carried genuine danger. But it rests on a real, distinctive opening: a state that has itself acknowledged an existential, largely self-inflicted water crisis, and built programmes to address it. On that ground, the dams and over-extraction that drive the crisis can be scrutinised technically and scientifically; the Hyrcanian forests, a world treasure, can be defended through the international heritage frameworks; the deadly dust from the exposed lakebeds is visible, measurable evidence no one can deny; and Iran's strong science carries the technical case. The levers are technical, within-system, and constrained, and the prize is the crisis pressed toward reform, a project scrutinised, the forests defended — on the state's own acknowledged terms, not an open stop. For a closed but crisis-conscious state, that careful, technical, strictly environmental work — never political, and protecting everyone involved absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.